

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a magazine:

Urban farming

Around 90 percent of the food eaten in Hong Kong is imported from Mainland China and other locations. But while Hong Kong is one of the most crowded places on earth, there is still considerable space to grow food locally.

Urban farming promoters say growing food in unusual spaces – on mall rooftops, housing estate terraces, even in office buildings – could help the environment and improve local health.

“Growing your own food is a necessary skill that we all need to learn to ensure a sustainable and green planet,” said one urban farmer. “Nothing is more important than the education of the next generation of urban farmers. Now is the time.”

There are now more than 60 rooftop farms across Hong Kong, growing foods like carrots, radishes, and fruit. Yet more than 600 million square metres of rooftops are still unused. “This situation needs to change,” said the farmer. “Rooftops in Hong Kong are often empty, open spaces that are not in use. Why not take advantage of this?”

Benefits of local urban farming include lower pollution levels due to less shipping, better access to healthy fruits and vegetables, and a sense of community spirit among urban farmers. The food can also be given to poor families or homeless people to reduce the problem of hunger.

You are members of the school’s Cookery Club. Your group would like to start an urban farm on your school’s rooftop. You are meeting to discuss this. You may want to talk about:

- the benefits of having a farm on the school’s rooftop
- how you will organise the care of the farm
- what you will do with the food you grow
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you think farming is a good hobby?
2. Are you interested in visiting rooftop farms?
3. If you had a farm, what would you grow?
4. Why do people enjoy visiting farms?
5. Are young people more interested in farming these days?
6. Should schools offer after-school farming classes?
7. Other than farming, what else can rooftops be used for?
8. What are the possible problems of having a rooftop farm?